As Humayun prepared to leave, two spies were caught and brought before him. It was in keeping with Humayun's luck that they managed to kill several men, women and horses[38] before being slain themselves, with the result that when the camp was ready to move Hamida had no horse to ride. Humayun, summoning what authority he could, asked Tardi Beg – whose desertion he had prevented mid-toilette – for his horse. It was one of Tardi Beg's horses that Humayun had ridden when he fled Kannauj, but now the chief had reached the shallow limits of his generosity. Unmoved by Hamida's swollen belly, Tardi Beg refused; Humayun had to give up his own mount and ride, for a while, on Jouher's camel.

Jouher does not tell this story; his is worse. In his telling, an officer called Roshan Beg proved even more cold-hearted than Tardi – he took away the horse on which Hamida was already mounted, having lent her the animal previously and now lost his own. This story ends like the other: with Humayun, son of Babur, heir to the rich plains of Hindustan, the dynasties of Timur the Lame and Chinghis Khan, barely able to provide a horse for his pregnant wife, seeking shelter in the desert, lurching upon a camel.

And yet, he had reason to be grateful. There were many in the company, both men and women, who were on foot, and even the animals found it hard to carry on: the horses in particular 'kept sinking to the knees in the sand'.[39] Humayun appointed Tardi Beg and Munim Khan to hang back and guard the company's flank against any possible attack by Maldeo; himself, he rode ahead, with twenty-odd soldiers to protect the harem, the slaves and the court astrologer, Maulana Chand. 'On they went', this beleaguered party, 'thirsty and hungry', marching all night – the astrologer guiding them by the stars, perhaps – and at dawn they found a well. The horses, writes Gulbadan, had not had a drop to drink for three days.

The men and women, stiff-jointed, their feet blistered and throats dry, were only just moving towards the water when a moan spread through them, 'The Hindus are coming . . .'![40]

Tardi Beg and Munim Khan, deputed to prevent exactly this attack, had 'lost their way and gone off in another direction'.[41] Humayun sent the few soldiers with him to fight – some had to borrow horses from the harem. The rest of the company turned from the water and resumed their long march again, 'slowly, slowly on',[42] too tired even to flee with speed.